

Dreadful *her.*

Author: Nimra Tanveer

CHAPTER 1:

THE Beginnings

The forest was deep and dark around the pavement of that long road. The depth of the forest could be seen and felt stretched and was enough to provide goosebumps to a calm human soul.

Dark Night has spread fully demonstrating the midnight. The Darkness has enveloped everything, the mud, the rocks, the lake standing between a distant part within the forests, the trees, the leaves, but the sky was an exception by the glowing globe placed within.



The full moon could be seen within the hustling of leaves. Wind breezes were making leaves hustle and owls speak. Weird - tangy sound they made, felt alike the hounds' howling but bearing the coldness and darkness fully compatible to its' surrounding.

Without the owl's sound, there was a huge silence showcasing the emptiness and void had made their way in. No traces of humane life could be assumed.

Far, somewhere, the silence shattered by the thuds of running steps ... barefooted uneven steps, stumbling ones

Howling started again, whose sound was that? she couldn't guess. How could she when

She was running hysterically. Disheveled hair barely showing that it might be combed neatly into a braid this evening, now it was nowhere near a braid. Strands were flowing that had freed from the braid's imprisonment. The strands above the forehead had shorter length and they were covering her eyes, struggling against the wind breeze striking them by

the running of their human. While a few were frozen in place by the blood on the right side of her forehead. The dark blood has frosted with a few strands.

White dress, that had mud all over, was torn from behind and the torn piece of cloth was flapping with each and every thud, bloody crimson stains could be observed on the torn piece of cloth.

She didn't know where to go, her mouth bleeding on the upper right corner of her lips, the gloss was showing on a few places mixed with dark crimson-red blood stains...unlike of this evening when she was sitting in front of the mirror, slid open the drawer and took out the gloss, his favorite shade of pink, she smiled and put that on in a fragile manner.

She rubbed her lips brutally running, the blood left its dark red shade on the back of her hand. She didn't bother it ... she couldn't, she knew one thing ... just Running and Running.

“Stop!! You Bitch!!” – He shouted from a distance lingering on one foot ... bleeding foot. And suddenly his pace got quicker.

“You Wouldn't be leaving this – (He spitted blood from his mouth on his left) – ALIVE , YOU ----- ” -The sound started coming nearer and nearer from her back.

She tried to run faster but with a thud on her shoulder, she fell down on her knees. In no time, He crawled over her,

“(He laughed along his raged breathing) HUH , What Now! --- ”, She could not understand what he was saying next.

She was helpless, struggling with numb senses, hands' fists losing their power to struggle and her mind, her heart, even every sense in her body, couldn't focus anymore.

She barely looked at the human shaped animal shouting something on her with sight blurred by the tears and the redness, salted water drops slipped from her eye corners and then her gaze moved a little, on the right of his head, there she could see the moon on its peak visualizing every event. And The Sky.

Her eyes were already not giving a clear view, brain pounding hard with the its walls, heart racing frantically as the ribs are on the verge to break through.

her senses going Numb,
the only thing she knew was,
THE Sky

Present Day

He slowly opened his eyes and looked at the Sky with a Blurry sight and redness by the late sleep and early wake - dizziness hasn't left him completely yet, still lingering somewhere in the eye corners.

He was on a comfy sofa on the terrace and he had no idea when his eyes got weary and shut down while working last night. The laptop was on a bistro table with an empty coffee mug beside it. He sat straight brushing his eyes slightly and looked at his watch. He missed Fajr again today, he sighed leaning his head on the sofa back, closing eyes and placing a hand on his forehead. *“What a loss”*

Finally he stood up holding his things and taking the stairs going down that lead directly to his own room backdoor.

After praying for fajr by 10 am and getting ready for office by 11, he stepped out of his room, one hand was straightening the tie and the other was checking emails as a client was expected to leave a message.

When he put his phone in his side pocket, his gaze moved towards the door right next to his. For a moment, he thought and then took two steps that led him in front of that closed door.

There was a slight knocking on the door. She quickly closed the Book she was reading and in one swift motion placed it under her pillow. By the time the door was open, she was already found in a peaceful sleep, well she assumed that maybe.

He slowly stepped towards the bed and stood right beside her, she could feel each and every movement by practice for several days ... he sighed with a soft gaze and in a soft tone almost whispering -- ***“huh! Nice ...”***.

She could hear the footsteps getting away and slightly opened her one eye ... he was standing in front of the dressing;

she could see his back, wearing a white shirt and black pants. One hand was in his side pocket, with the other one he was placing some tablets there, his dark brown hair were lengthier enough to touch the back collar of his shirt. He brushed his hair after decently placing the tablets there and turned ... found her sleep peacefully as before, he chuckled as if he didn't observe the movements of her reflection from the mirror and stepped out of the room, closing the door with a thud.

She quickly got up sitting straight looking at the table where the headache tablets were placed showing something she was ignoring for days,

“Why do I care!” With her usual nonchalant behavior she didn't bother standing up and taking a look. Just took the Novel out and started the suspense story she was reading earlier. _____

By the time he reached office, team was already waiting for him in the boarding room. The screen was lit by the presentation slides showing off a revenue plan while people were chanting. On the right side, Mr. Meer was discussing the matter with the client and looked at his wrist for twice, when finally Ahad entered the room in a rushy pace. A serious look was received By Mr. Meer when he held his position by the lit screen and everyone started focusing.

“First, I really apologize for reaching here at ..” - he looked down at his smart watch smiling and on the sight ahead slightly narrowed his eyes.

“... 5 minutes prior the meeting.” - always with his Ahad-like apologizing behaviour that made the team chuckle.

If he wouldn't be the senior employee transferred from London Head-Office to Pakistan branch, the CEO, Mr. Meer wouldn't have tolerated such insolence.

“Okay, Let's start.” - and the rest of the meeting went very well. Pacing with confident tread, raising voice where required attention, moving hands along with the presentation and most importantly smiling from time to time made the great deal that ended up persuading the client and closing off a bigger project. He earned the day when at the end everyone handshaked with him.

Later, He was working in the office when his phone started ringing .. the bright screen was showing a picture of him with an older woman , the screen said : ***“Biaa Calling”***

“Salaam Biaa .. how are you”, No sooner had he greeted when a joyous childish voice appeared from behind the screen...

“Mamuu , when .. will you come ... mama just .. punished .. me” , -- Ahad laughed genuinely on his way of talking.

“Awww , Where is Mama, Mamuu will take your revenge , YES?” - The kid on other side showed a much stronger expression by saying ***“YESSS”*** like his purpose of calling was achieved, He could hear the voices of her elder sister coming,

“Sher...Sherry , give me that ... Salaam Ahad , Wait a moment, Sherryyyy .. stop ... I am saying this very last time ..” He was amused by listening to all that stuff.

“They are just becoming so stubborn day by day.. How are you and How is Huriya ”. She sounded cared when she finally succeeded in snatching phone back from sherry. Ahad's smile faded a bit

“Well I am great as always and --- (he sighed), and Huriya is a bit --- Strange”. He paused for a moment.

“hmm, I got you ... she would adjust, give her some time. I remember how her laughter used to circle around in our house ... sher... Sherry ... when I alrea...”.

He wasn't listening to ... what Biaa was talking next after associating laughter with her, his wife, who never even smiled for 3 months , since the day they got married ...

besides eating together, they barely talked and she had laughs? , before? Why doesn't she laugh now ? Is he the reason? Is she just surviving the decision that was his - alone?

“Ahad?? Are you there??” He suddenly was pulled out of his thoughts

“Umm – Yeah , I .. I just have some work to do.. can we talk later!” ... his voice was rushed demonstrating the thoughts in his mind.

“Okay but visit baba this week, He was asking for you and Do give love to Huriya from my side .. okay .. BYee, Take Care - Allah Hafiz” –

“Allah Hafiz” - He cut the call and saw Biaa's text ,,

“Make Sure to continue giving her a little more care! [Emoji with heart]”.He reacted with a heart and unintentionally scrolled up where he saw the date

--11th May 2021—

Text : “She is the girl I talked about , Huriya Dastageer” with a picture of her.

He clicked on the picture ... and there she was, completely unaware that someone had captured that moment forever, sitting on a chair with her legs crossed comfortably, not looking at the camera at all but rather staring somewhere in the distance as though something had caught her attention , and on her face was a smile ... so genuine and effortless that for a moment he found himself forgetting everything else around him.

A dark hijab framed her bright features gracefully while the evening sunlight rested softly upon her face her light brown eyes seemed alive with something he had not seen in months and the curve of her lips carried a happiness that appeared so natural that it hurt him to realize he had never witnessed that version of her himself.

One hand was wrapped around her handbag while the other rested near her hijab as though she had been adjusting it at that exact moment and somebody had taken the picture without her knowledge ... capturing not just her appearance but an entire piece of her personality in a single frame.

He zoomed further into her picture.

And kept staring. Not because she was the kind of woman the world would stop and call *breathtakingly beautiful* nor because she possessed the sort of beauty poets spent lifetimes writing about.

But because she looked perfect. - Alive. - Genuine - Soo her.

His eyes softened unconsciously as he continued looking at her picture wondering how many stories were hidden behind those smiling eyes ... wondering what had stolen that spark away and most of all wondering whether there would ever come a day when she would smile like that in front of him ? Well he decided one thing ... he wouldn't give up on her ... Not on *her*

11th May 2021

She was looking at her brother and his wife from a distance sitting at a cornered chair and honestly speaking, they looked disgustingly perfect together

The way Rayan would lean slightly towards Abiha while talking the way Abiha would smile before he even completed his sentence the way they seemed to exist inside their own little world despite being surrounded by hundreds of people

They looked like one of those couples' people secretly envied and publicly called "Made for Each Other"

A smile found its way onto Huriya's face as she watched them

It was the first family gathering at their house after a fortnight of her brother's marriage and the atmosphere was overflowing with laughter , relatives , children running around and endless congratulations.

And Biao

Well

Biao was amazing.

Not only had she become a wonderful wife for her brother but somehow she had also adopted Huriya as her unofficial best friend.

No matter that it had been a love marriage. Huriya had always been firmly on her brother's side during the entire battle of convincing their parents.

This function was huge. Not only relatives but office colleagues , old friends and distant family acquaintances had also been invited.

The entire lawn was glowing beneath warm lights and decorated with white and pink roses that swayed gently with the evening breeze.

At nineteen years of age and in the final month of her FSc, She still considered herself far too young to understand how the world actually worked, especially when it came to things like marriage.

Or men.

Or whatever mysterious disease made people stare at each other and suddenly decide to spend their entire lives together.

She got up to have a drink and reached out to the lemonade stand on one side of the huge lawn that was decorated for the function with pink and white roses and green leafy stems surrounding the tables ... she could sense some footsteps appearing beside her.

“Can I get one?” she heard a manly voice and looked up.

A man wearing a black tuxedo .. light beard that suit him and tall with neatly set black hair, hand stretched with an empty glass and he was smiling while looking at her with something in his eyes,

“Sure!” without a second thought she put the lemonade in his glass through the Jar she was holding.

“Hooriya Dastagir? Rayan’s Sister I guess?” he sipped from the lemonade looking at her. On hearing her name from a stranger, well a good looking one , she squinted her eyes meeting his gaze .. ***“Yes .. !?”***

“Haha, I’m Mahir ... Mahir Baig. Rayan used to mention you a lot , I didn’t know you were a grown up. I thought you would be this little by his talk ”, he gestured with his one hand

(“Now how do he expect me to react”) – she thought looking around ... maybe her mother would call out or at least his only brother could appear but no one was coming to rescue her for now.

“I think my mother needs me .. well see you later then, Enjoy ” she finally gathered courage to make an excuse with a forced smile.

“Ahan, Later when?” – he waved the glass in a slight circular motion looking at the lemonade that was slightly flowing inside. There was no funny clue in his fixed gaze.

“What !?” - unintentionally the question slipped. Her expression had already shifted to uneasiness.

“Maybe you didn’t mean what you said (he placed the glass down)... But I definitely plan on seeing you ... later” - she could see him step back with his gaze fixed at her and then finally turned towards a group of people

For a moment her brain stopped functioning. (“wait ... what?”)
Then restarted, then stopped again.

What kind of answer was that? Who even says things like that?

“What a Jerk!!” – she said to herself with visible irritation on her face and ... with something else she completely ignored.

The whole function went weird afterwards, she was moving back and forth between her room and the lawn, she didn’t want to disappear from the function being the only sister of his brother and she couldn’t bear those intense eyes too

She avoided looking at people directly until everyone started to leave.

She forbad goodbyes with a genuine smile and eventually was caught up by a woman asking about .. when her studies are going to end. She looked for her mother who was far away sitting with a bunch of other women taking their leaves .. and then her gaze flickered upon him ...

He was standing with his brother and two other men , quite older ones ... they were discussing something .. the man she met earlier had a coat on his one arm and he was talking to Rayan, smiling.

Suddenly the old man said something and all of them laughed.

And he laughed .. her gaze stayed on his face for a little longer than expected observing how well his teeth were, straight and white. and unexpectedly he looked directly at her .. she stumbled being caught red-handed.

(“WHATT a Jerk You are Hoor ...”), The woman was gone and she was standing alone there ... she quicked her pace towards her room locking the door --- trying to breathe evenly.

(“You are such a pervert”) ... she shut her eyes blaming herself and her hands covered her face as if she could hide the earlier embarrassment .

(“But he is kinda .. handsome though”) – she chuckled, shaking her head.

(“So what?? Why should I care ”) – she tried to be serious and came towards her dressing unfolding her hijab.

(“Maybe He is interested in marrying me”) – A small smile crept on her lips thinking that .. she took the hair clip off and her long black hair fell like a stream. A few strands touched her neck in the most fragile way possible.

(“One man looked at me for ten minutes and I have already planned an entire proposal in my head”) - A dramatic sigh escaped her... (“soo bad girl.”)

(“Maybe he does the same thing with every other women”) – she sighed again

("yes maybe , I am average though") – she looked at her reflection in the mirror ...

("but .. maybe not") – she knocked it off from her head by focusing on getting a peaceful sleep not knowing that it was not possible from this very day.

When finally after praying esha , she slipped under her blanket and closed her eyes, his face appeared on the blank screen asking for lemonade , she smiled and opened her eyes slowly,

("jerk") – she closed her eyes again

Present day

She slightly opened her eyes ... there was a little redness shown by sleep There were no lights in the room, the outside window was open that used to open in the lawn .. she could see the dark night , perfect half-moon from here, she sit up against the back of the bed and clicked ON the lamp on her side , the clock on the front wall was showing 3:13 am.

She removed the blanket and walked outside the room. She had forgotten to count the days she was having the same wake ups. The water splashed on her face as she washed it and raised her head to look in the front mirror. Her reflection was quite different than her old teenager self.

She had medium flat eyebrows and chestnut coloured eyes, the lashes were damped by the water and were long enough that tiny drops could be seen at their corners, her face was more mature with the traces of youth she was carrying as she was twenty five by now. She came towards her room and stood at the door glancing on the closed door next to her for two mere seconds and then moving on.

After placing the prayer mat she sat down slowly.

The silence around her was so complete that it felt as though the entire world had stepped back ... Leaving only her and Allah.

"Allah"

The word escaped her lips softly... Not as a prayer. or a request

But as someone calling the One they loved.

And suddenly her heart felt lighter. Because every believer knows something beautiful before we call upon Him ... He already knows.

Before tears reach our eyes ... He already sees them.

Before pain reaches our lips ... He already understands it.

A smile crept onto her face.

"You are great You know that?"-The answer came not as a voice ... But as for certainty. The kind certainty only faith brings And her heart remembered.

("And when My servants ask you concerning Me Indeed I am near.")

Her eyes softened.

"Ya Allah I have spent more than a hundred days trying to outrun a fear that no longer exists and somehow I am still standing at the same place"

A tear slipped down her cheek.... ***"I know he is a good man"***

Another tear followed.

"I know You sent him into my life for a purpose .. indeed"

Her voice trembled. ... ***"Then what's it , I don't know but you do... right?"***

And another ayah surfaced gently within her heart.

("We know what is in your hearts.")

She chuckled through her tears, ***"You always win arguments"***

The slight chuckle echoed softly in the room. A broken laugh But a genuine one.

"Inni Uhibbuka Ya Allah"

"I really do."

Her fingers brushed against the prayer mat.

"And I want to become better for You."

The tears no longer felt heavy. The fear no longer felt unbearable.

("Indeed, you are in front of our eyes and we are seeing you.") She assumed Him talking to angels , Telling them about her, Telling them He loves her back .. an ayah came to her mind

("And Remember me, so I will remember you!")

The serenity surrounded her in the best way possible, she contracted her legs and wrapped her arms around them putting her chin on her knees... talking to Allah in her heart.

Time to time, sometimes she smiles as her gaze softens, ... sometimes tears start rushing out and in between there were broken laughs.

One would have assumed her mentally unstable if the one doesn't understand what it's like having a conversation with Allah. That was the most spiritually stable state for her to be in.

Dawn was a bit different than others ... Ahad didn't come out of his room since Fajr had called. Usually during Fajr she hears his footsteps but today there was nothing .. they ate last night as usual then what's it ? Wouldn't he have to pray ? did he go out late at night. She came out of her room thinking all that and stood right in front of his room.

(Should I? or Should I not? .. But Hoor you just promised Allah to change and you have to answer about the promises you kept --- Okay Okay I am opening , now stop it)...

She knocked her thoughts off by shaking her head and sighed ... with a racing heart placed her hand on the handle of his door .. just then the knob moved on its own and the door opened. He was standing with messy hair and a sleepy face that changed expression on seeing her.

“Uh. I ... I was Just ..”- She swallowed something.

“!!?” – he was questioning with his eyes .. **“Is everything okay?”**

“yes .. I was just concerned ... Your fajr was .. umm .. kind of missed”

“Oh... ohkay .. you were concerned .. hmm” – he stepped out leaning on the doorside by his side crossing arms with his usual amusement that made its way besides the sleep.

“Now you are awake, I should be .. leaving”, she hesitated .. and this is how she always used to avoid *the* conversations.

“I couldn't sleep due to office work and my head is still pounding .. it was difficult to get out of bed for Fajr.” He explained seeing her again trying to end a barely started conversation.

“I have the medicine you gave me , if you want I can ... ”

“Yes Please,” He smiled, cutting her mid-sentence. She nodded and headed towards her room without staying for another second.

(huff , WHATTT a disguise .. then why did you even step out there well, I didn't know this would happen) – she heard the tap water sound from afar , he was already doing wudu .. the Fajr time was going to end soon.

When she returned, the door was open. She slowly stepped in. That Fragrance , she had hardly come to this room 5-6 times in hundred days and she can guess he only uses one Scent, the sweet Bergamot scent maybe.. a few things had changed since her last visit.

2kg dumbbells have been replaced by 5kg ones. There was a new stand placed there, a gym stand she guessed for uplifts, the king sized bed had wrinkled sheets, side table was messy with a coffee cup, his MAC and pens, diaries etc and in an opposite corner of the room he was praying.

Her gaze stopped there for more than a few seconds when she started looking for some room on the side table to place the pain killer. As he finished praying, he came towards her, folding the prayer mat.

Grabbed water from her and took the pain killer from her palm. In a quick motion, he tossed the painkiller inside and drank water drowning it down with one single gulp.

“Okay ... Take a rest ... I will be leaving.”

“hmm.” - he nodded knowing they had the longest interaction this week.

“can you - ” She turned to step out when his words made her stop.

“Cook something, I didn’t eat home-cooked for days ... ” He said getting comfortable in his bed .. his head was actually pounding but he didn’t want to let that moment waste. He might convince her to get out of her shell.

“Yeah .. Sure” and then she didn’t look back and came to her room closing the door

(“HUH! , What do I do Noww”) She started pacing here and there in a quick manner

(“When did you even last cook ?”)

(“Okay Relax .. You can do that”) ... she took a deep breath (“I can do that!”)

“I know he will do that!” – Teenager Huriya was saying with pure amusement and something else. Her voice was echoing in the empty hallway and her friends were making a circle around her.

It was their college. A large building was standing behind the staircase they were sitting on. The girls were listening attentively to her with a spark in their eyes.

“You’re being ridiculous Hoor. it was merely a ... umm.. a flirty line that meant nothing.” -one of them tried to throw a reality check that didn’t even flinch her mood.

“You are just envious!” - Another one laughed ***“because you are the only one who hasn’t yet met anyone ... well leave her Hoor, tell us more!!”*** – she seemed more excited giving a shut-up call to the reality checker.

“Huh! Soon I will be engaged and you guys will see a diamond ring here!” – she stretched her hand showing fingers as she lifted her ring finger, in a manner that made everyone laugh again.

“well I hope so ..”— the reality checker smirked, rolling her eyes.

“what is your problem dude, I know you are a man hater but let her be happy”— someone else interrupted. Huriya was getting amused by their reactions but there was something deep down in her heart, something that was asking her to stop, to not show any amusement over that, to step back and run ... run towards what? ... from whom? ... she had no idea ... well maybe she could find out only if ... she wanted to.

But .. she let her amusement win She let her ... desires win over her heart , over her inner voice.

“At least tell us his name .. our future brother-to-be ”- the staircase erupted in laughter again.

She took a pause and looked at everyone being so attentive like she was exposing Newton’s theory to a science department of NASA.

“Well, let’s not make a fuss over that, I know you guys are ridiculous ”

“Oh Com’onnn” – an impatient one tugged her on her shoulders that made her laugh.

“Well, ... Mahir Baig!” – and a burst of playful tugs and laughter burst out once again making the hallway students stop their conversations and look at the group of girls.

Present

The whole day was delightful. Ahad worked in the office smiling and getting compliments of how fresh he was working today. He took an early leave saying he had dinner plans with his wife and using the word his wife, he was smiling by heart ...

He got into the car , drove his way home and carried a flower bucket with him ... red roses enveloped in black paper.

“I hope she doesn’t think this is too much” – he talked to himself carrying that bucket while parking his car aside on their home street.

He stepped out of it and walked towards the house ... took a deep breath before standing in front of the Door and placed his hand on the door knob .. he rolled it and pushed slightly when he saw the huge black smoke clouds getting out of the Kitchen ..

"What the .. " - his pace quickened towards the kitchen and he wasn't ready for what was waiting inside.

The steel bowl was black with large hot flames enveloping it , the whole kitchen was filled with stinging smoke and the unbearable heat.

He quickly placed the bucket on a side shelf ... the flames had gotten the handkerchief hanging by the wall and there was still a bit of water inside the steel pot bowling in a frantic way.

He switched off the stove, and groaned when the frantic boiling water flew on his hand ... With stinging pain he picked the towel and put the burning black steel pot under tap , opening it in full swing.

He threw the handkerchief away avoiding it spreading anywhere else unaware that the flames got the red roses behind him ... the flames rose up completely swallowing the redness of roses and gradually fizzled out.

And when saw that the situation was under control, placed his hands on his knees breathing heavily.

His eyes closed for a brief moment amidst the chaos.

Then he heard it. ---- A faint sob. So quiet that it almost drowned beneath the noise. His gaze searched the room and stopped. There she was.

Curled up in the corner beneath the shelf, pressed tightly against the wall as if she wished she could disappear into it. Her arms were wrapped around her knees, holding them desperately against her chest. Her face had lost all color. Trembling legs refused to stay still, and her shoulders shook with silent cries.

For a second, his heart dropped.

"Hey... hey..." He hurried toward her, crouching beside her. **"What happened?"**

As though his voice had startled her from somewhere far away.

Slowly, she looked up. ... Her eyes were red and swollen, but it wasn't the tears that unsettled him.....It was the fear.---Pure.---Raw.---Terrifying fear.

The kind that made a person look as though they were seeing something no one else could.

"Huriya..."

Her lips parted.

"So... sorr..." The words broke apart beneath her sobs.

"No, no." His voice softened immediately. **"Please don't talk like that It's okay. You don't need to apologize."**

A fresh wave of tears escaped her.

"It's okay..." he repeated helplessly, wishing he knew what had scared her so badly. Her breathing grew faster.... Short.....Shallow.....Panicked.

"Huriya, look at me." he said slightly raising her chin..... She tried. Failed. Tried again.

Without thinking further, he gently pulled her toward him. For a moment she stiffened.... Then the fight seemed to leave her body all at once. He wrapped his arms around her trembling frame, one hand settling on the back of her head with knuckles having redness by the bowling water that just stung him.

"Shhh..." he whispered. **"You're safe.... I am here"**

A sob escaped her.

"You're safe."

His shirt quickly dampened with tears as she buried her face against his chest, clutching the fabric with shaking fingers....

A small flame was still taking its last breath on one of the dark red roses over a reddish part ... slowly it fizzles out .. the redness started to narrow down to a smaller and smaller circle with the burning darkness spreading around ... and then it completely burnt out, leaving no shade of red there...

leaving a bucket of burnt black roses there
